MERCY'S ANATOMY

Season 2, Episode 15

"Walk Out"

Episode 2x15. The counterpart of *Grey's Anatomy* 2x15 (the nurses' strike). Narrator: Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock

In-story dates: Monday, January 30, 2006 (QGH nurses' one-day strike), 5:56 AM through 11:58 PM

Script: Cold Open + 5 Acts + Tag. 44 scenes. Standard: MA-009

Depends on MA-001 through MA-011 and episodes 1x01-2x14

EPISODE PDF PACKAGE (MA-009 §6): 1. Title page and cast (with ages on Monday, January 30, 2006). 2. Script. 3. Media Companion. 4. Continuity Sheet.

Cast in Order of Appearance (Ages on Monday, January 30, 2006)

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Nurse Kendra Wallace	Surgical Floor Nurse (on strike)	May 30, 1980	25
Nurse Yvette Banks	CVICU Charge Nurse (on strike)	Dec 1, 1963	42
Nurse Gloria Pettiford	Head ER Nurse (management)	Apr 14, 1952	53
Dr. Elxa Bullock	Surgical Resident (38 weeks 5 days; desk duty)	Aug 29, 1977	28
Russell Jeffries	Elxa's husband	Apr 3, 1975	30
Raymond 'Big Ray' Toles	Chief of Security	Jan 1, 1960	46
Dr. Sylvia Rountree	President and CEO	Dec 2, 1951	54
Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock	Surgical Intern (narrator)	Jan 5, 1979	27
Dr. Amond Baker	Surgical Intern	Feb 10, 1979	26
Dr. Harmony Divine	Surgical Intern	Jun 19, 1979	26
Dr. Natasha Donohue	Chief of Surgery	Jun 2, 1958	47
Dr. Raven Ellison	Surgical Intern	Dec 3, 1979	26
Dr. Arianna Cummings	Surgical Intern	Oct 25, 1979	26
Dr. Esther Smilley	Surgical Intern	Sep 20, 1979	26
Dr. Bryce Kennerly	Surgical Intern	Jun 11, 1978	27
Mrs. Lavinia Stroud (new)	Patient: respiratory arrest; DNR/DNI	Oct 8, 1914	91
Josiah Wiggins (new)	Patient, 16: pelvic and femur fractures, hemorrhagic shock	Sep 9, 1989	16
Brother Clifford Wiggins (new)	Josiah's father	Jun 12, 1961	44
Sister Joyce Wiggins (new)	Josiah's mother	Nov 1, 1963	42
Dr. Abraham Lowery	Attending General Surgeon	Jan 9, 1947	59
Dr. Camille Toussaint	Orthopedic Resident	Jul 21, 1976	29
Darius 'Dash' Duvall	Patient: Status 1A, day 80	Aug 8, 1971	34
Glenda Duvall	Dash's mother	Dec 12, 1947	58
Cora Stroud (new)	Lavinia's daughter; retired principal	Apr 30, 1939	66
Dr. Cyrus Langley (new)	Patient: valve replacement; Robert's Howard professor	Jul 17, 1927	78
Dr. Robert Bullock	Chief of Cardiothoracic Surgery	Feb 10, 1956	49
Howard Divine	Harmony's father (TWU, in solidarity)	Aug 30, 1950	55
Franklin Bassett, Esq.	General Counsel	Oct 28, 1958	47
Justice Harold Dukes (V.O., new)	Supreme Court, Queens County	Feb 2, 1949	56

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Lamont 'Monty' Gaines	Owner, Monty's on Jackson	Oct 10, 1962	43
Dr. Clayton Hartwell	OB/GYN and Fetal Surgeon	Mar 3, 1971	34
Mrs. Eunice Langley (new)	Cyrus's wife	May 5, 1929	76
Lillian Divine	Harmony's mother	Feb 14, 1952	53
Mercy	The House's pit bull puppy	Sep 30, 2005	0

Also appearing: about 260 striking NYSNA nurses, 94 Premier Clinical Staffing replacement nurses, paramedics, an agency respiratory therapist, a chaplain and a fax machine. Mentioned: Marisol (Mrs. Stroud's regular nurse), Mrs. Ocasio (CVICU Bed 7), Dr. Hampton, Dr. Delphine Ware (d. 2003) and Malcolm Sloan (by email).

COLD OPEN

1 EXT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MAIN ENTRANCE - PRE-DAWN
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 5:56 AM

Cold and dark. Along the sidewalk on Jackson Avenue, sixty nurses in red NYSNA union jackets stand behind police barricades with signs: "SAFE STAFFING SAVES LIVES," "1 NURSE : 8 PATIENTS = NOBODY'S SAFE," "WE CARE FOR YOU -- WHO CARES FOR US?" Among them: Nurse Kendra Wallace (25), and CVICU charge nurse Yvette Banks (42) with a bullhorn.

YVETTE
(into the bullhorn)
What do we want?

NURSES
(chanting)
Safe staffing!

YVETTE
When do we want it?

NURSES
Now!

A figure in a long wool coat crosses the street toward the entrance with a thermos: Gloria Pettiford (53), Head ER Nurse. Management. She can't strike. The chanting falters. Thirty years of nurses look at her.

KENDRA
(quietly)
Gloria.

Gloria stops at the barricade. She looks at her nurses for a long moment. Then she sets the thermos down on top of the barricade.

GLORIA
(beat)
Coffee. (beat) Hazelnut. (beat)
The good kind.

MARC (V.O.)
Every hospital runs on one secret.

She walks through the revolving door into the hospital. Behind her, the chant starts up again, louder.

2 INT. ELXA AND RUSSELL'S HOUSE - ST. ALBANS - KITCHEN - PRE-DAWN
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 6:04 AM

Elxa (28), 38 weeks and 5 days pregnant, in maternity scrubs, sits at the kitchen table, scowling at a bowl of oatmeal. Russell (30) packs her bag with granola bars, a water bottle and a bright purple seat cushion.

ELXA
(beat)
Desk duty.

RUSSELL
(beat)
Desk duty.

ELXA
(beat)
I'm a third-year surgical resident, Russell. (beat) I've done four hundred and twelve cases. (beat) And today, I'm going to sit in a chair and answer the phone.

RUSSELL
(zipping the bag)
You're going to sit in a chair and answer the phone and not deliver our son in an elevator.

MARC (V.O.)
It isn't the surgeons. It isn't the machines.

ELXA
(beat)
The nurses are striking today. (beat) Sixty percent. (beat) The floors are going to be a disaster. (beat) And I'm going to be in a chair.

RUSSELL
(kissing the top of her head)
Then you'll be the best-informed chair in Queens.

MARC (V.O.)
It's the people we stop seeing because they're always there.

END OF COLD OPEN

ACT ONE

3 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MAIN LOBBY - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 6:31 AM

Controlled chaos. Two white vans marked "PREMIER CLINICAL STAFFING" have pulled up to the service entrance. Replacement nurses with rolling bags and lanyards stream into the lobby. Big Ray Toles (46), at the front desk, checks IDs. Dr. Sylvia Rountree (54), the CEO, stands with a clipboard. Marc (26), Amond (26) and Harmony (26) come in from the cold.

BIG RAY
(to the interns, low)
One day. (beat) Seven a.m. today to seven a.m. tomorrow. (beat) They gave the ten-day notice on the twentieth.

HARMONY
(looking at the vans)
How many replacements?

BIG RAY
(beat)
Ninety-four. (beat) For two hundred and sixty nurses outside.

AMOND
(beat)
That's a third.

BIG RAY
(beat, grimly)
And none of them know where we keep anything.

Rountree catches sight of them.

ROUNTREE
(crisp)
Doctors. (beat) The Chief of Surgery is waiting for you on Five. (beat) I hope you know how to hang a bag.

4 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL FLOOR - NURSES' STATION - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 6:52 AM

Natasha (47), in scrubs rather than her usual suit, stands at the station. Elxa sits behind the desk on the purple cushion with three phones and the board. The interns gather: Marc, Raven (26), Harmony, Amond, Arianna (26), Esther (26) and Kennerly (27). An agency nurse in brand-new scrubs hovers nervously behind them.

NATASHA
(beat)
For the next twenty-four hours, every one of you is a nurse. (beat) You will hang your own drips. You will check your own vitals. You will empty your own Foleys. You will turn your own patients every two hours so they don't get bedsores. (beat) If you've never done that, ask the agency nurse next to you. (beat) If she's never done it in this building, ask Nurse Pettiford. (beat) You will not complain. (beat) Those women and men outside do this every day with eight patients each. (beat) That's why they're outside.

A silence. The interns look at each other.

ELXA
(reading off)
Bullock: Six North, the medical overflow. Twelve patients. You and one agency nurse. (beat) Ellison: CVICU. You and two agency nurses for eight beds. (beat) Baker: Cardio step-down. (beat) Cummings, Divine: ER trauma, with Lowery and Toussaint. (beat) Smilley: Neuro ICU. Kennerly: ER, with Pettiford. (beat) Questions?

KENNERLY
(beat)
How do you empty a Foley?

ELXA
(beat, not looking up)
Quickly.

5 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - 6 NORTH - ROOM 618 - MORNING

MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 7:16 AM

A double room. In the window bed: MRS. LAVINIA STROUD (91), a tiny, white-haired woman, gasping in short, failing breaths, lips blue. The oxygen mask has slipped off her face. No nurse. The call light above the bed has been blinking for who knows how long. Marc comes in on his first round, sees her and drops the clipboard.

MARC
(rushing to her)
Mrs. Stroud? (beat) Mrs. Stroud!

No response. Her breathing stops. Marc checks her pulse. Faint. Slow. He slams the code button on the wall.

MARC
(shouting into the hallway)
I need a crash cart in six-eighteen! (beat) Respiratory arrest!

He scans her wrists. No colored bracelet. He glances at the bed rail, at the board above the bed. "DIET: PUREED. FALL RISK." Nothing else. The agency nurse runs in with the cart, frightened.

AGENCY NURSE
(breathless)
What do you need?

MARC
(already grabbing the laryngoscope)
Bag-valve mask. Suction. Seven-oh tube. (beat) Is there a code status on her?

AGENCY NURSE
(beat, panicked)
I don't know. (beat) I've been here twenty minutes. (beat) They handed me twelve patients and a binder.

Marc looks at the tiny woman, gray and dying. No bracelet. No sign. No time.

MARC
(tilting her head back)
Then we treat. (beat) Bag her.

He slides the blade in, lifts and sees the cords. The tube goes in. The agency nurse bags. Mrs. Stroud's chest rises. On the monitor, her heart rate climbs back up: fifty, sixty, seventy-two. Her color returns.

MARC
(breathing hard)
Okay. (beat) Okay. (beat) Get respiratory. (beat) Get her to the ICU. (beat) And find me her chart.

6 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - TRAUMA 1 - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 7:33 AM

Paramedics rush in a gurney. JOSIAH WIGGINS (16), tall and skinny, in a torn Bayside High School jacket, moans in a cervical collar. His right thigh is visibly deformed. His father, BROTHER CLIFFORD WIGGINS (44), in a suit and tie, and his mother, SISTER JOYCE WIGGINS (42), follow behind. Lowery (59), Arianna and Harmony meet them. Camille (29) is right behind.

PARAMEDIC
Car versus pole on the Clearview. (beat) Restrained passenger. (beat) Mom was driving, black ice. (beat) Obvious right femur fracture. Pelvis unstable. Pressure ninety over fifty.

LOWERY
(calm)
On my count. (beat) One, two, three.

They slide him onto the trauma bed. Harmony cuts away the jacket. Camille presses gently on his pelvis, and he screams.

CAMILLE
(beat)
Open-book pelvis. (beat) Binder. Now. (beat) And traction on that femur.

ARIANNA
(reading the monitor)
Heart rate one thirty-two. Pressure eighty-four. (beat) Hemoglobin on the iSTAT, six-point-one. (beat) Two units O-negative, wide open. (beat) Type and cross six more.

Brother Wiggins steps forward. Calm. Absolutely firm.

CLIFFORD
(beat)
No blood.

Everyone stops.

CLIFFORD
(beat)
We are Jehovah's Witnesses. (beat) My son will not receive blood. (beat) I want that written down. (beat) Now.

JOSIAH
(through the pain, gasping)
No blood. (beat) Please. (beat) No blood.

7 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CVICU - BED 5 - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 7:51 AM

The CVICU, short-staffed. Raven, in scrubs, is hanging an amiodarone bag on Dash's pump herself, checking the rate twice. Dash (34), on day 80, sits up. Glenda (58) stands at the window with her knitting.

DASH
(watching her)
You're my nurse today?

RAVEN
(programming the pump)
I'm your nurse today. (beat) And Mr. Langley's in Bed 3. And Mrs. Ocasio's in Bed 7. (beat) And six more. (beat) With two agency nurses who've never seen a balloon pump.

DASH
(beat, grinning)
Do I get a sponge bath?

RAVEN
(not looking at him)
You get a chlorhexidine wipe-down at ten, like everybody else.

GLENDA
(from the window, dry)
I've given him a sponge bath since 1971, Dr. Ellison. (beat) I'll handle it. (beat) You go save Bed 3.

Raven smiles despite herself. She finishes with the pump and moves to the door.

DASH
(beat, quieter)
Raven. (beat) The nurses outside. (beat) Yvette? (beat) She's my nurse. (beat) She brought me a Panthers blanket from home. (beat) I hope they get what they want.

RAVEN
(beat)
So do I.

8 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CHIEF'S OFFICE - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 8:11 AM

Rountree stands in the doorway with a folder. Natasha, still in scrubs, sits at her desk drinking coffee from a paper cup.

ROUNTREE
(beat)
I'll be sending letters of discipline to any nurse who refuses mandatory overtime tomorrow. (beat) The board approved it on Friday.

NATASHA
(beat)
Sylvia. (beat) Six North had one RN for eight patients on the night shift last Tuesday. (beat) One. (beat) A ninety-one-year-old woman just had a respiratory arrest on Six North while her call light blinked for nobody.

ROUNTREE
(beat)
That was an agency nurse on a strike day.

NATASHA
(beat)
That was one nurse with twelve patients on a strike day, and one nurse with eight on a normal one. (beat) The difference isn't the strike, Sylvia. (beat) The strike is just when we finally noticed.

Rountree's jaw tightens.

ROUNTREE
(beat)
I have a hospital to keep solvent, Natasha. (beat) Medicaid reimbursement is down eleven percent. (beat) Every nurse I add is a hundred thousand dollars I don't have.

NATASHA
(beat, standing)
And every patient who dies on Six North because nobody answered a light costs more than that. (beat) Ask Franklin. (beat) He'll show you the settlements.

9 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MICU - BED 2 - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 8:37 AM

Mrs. Stroud, intubated, on a ventilator, her eyes now open and frightened above the tube. Marc stands beside the bed with her chart, finally found. The door bursts open. Her daughter, CORA STROUD (66), a retired high school principal, in a church coat, sees the ventilator and stops.

CORA
(beat, horrified)
No. (beat) No, no, no.

MARC
(beat)
Ms. Stroud. (beat) I'm Dr. Bullock. (beat) Your mother stopped breathing this morning, and I...

CORA
(beat, shaking)
She's DNR. (beat) Do Not Resuscitate. (beat) Do Not Intubate. (beat) We signed it in 2003, with her doctor, in front of a notary. (beat) It's in her chart. (beat) It's on the first page of her chart.

Marc looks down at the chart in his hands. He opens it. The first page. A bright orange form: "MOLST: DO NOT RESUSCITATE. DO NOT INTUBATE." Signed. Witnessed. Dated.

MARC
(barely)
It wasn't on the door. (beat) There was no bracelet. (beat) There was no nurse.

CORA
(beat, crying)
She's ninety-one years old. (beat) She buried my father and two of my brothers. (beat) She told me, "When God calls, I'm answering the phone." (beat) And you put a tube down her throat.

In the bed, Mrs. Stroud's eyes move from her daughter to Marc. She lifts one hand weakly toward the tube.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

10 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - TRAUMA 1 - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 8:52 AM

Josiah, in a pelvic binder, his right leg in traction, gray. The two units of O-negative hang unused on the IV pole, clamped shut. Lowery, Arianna, Camille and Harmony. Brother and Sister Wiggins stand together at the foot of the bed holding hands.

ARIANNA
(reading the iSTAT)
Hemoglobin five-point-two. (beat) Pressure seventy-eight. (beat) Lactate four.

LOWERY
(calm, to the parents)
Brother Wiggins. (beat) Your son is bleeding from his pelvis and his thigh. (beat) We can stabilize the bones in the OR. (beat) We can use a cell saver to recycle his own blood. (beat) We can give him iron and erythropoietin. (beat) But if his hemoglobin keeps falling, his heart will stop. (beat) Today.

CLIFFORD
(beat, steady)
We accept the cell saver, if the circuit stays connected to his body. (beat) We accept the medicines. (beat) We do not accept blood. (beat) Acts chapter fifteen, verse twenty-nine. (beat) "Abstain from blood."

JOYCE
(crying quietly)
We love our son, Doctor. (beat) Please understand. (beat) We love him more than this life.

ARIANNA
(low, furious, to Lowery)
He's sixteen. (beat) He's a minor. (beat) We can get a court order.

JOSIAH
(weak, from the bed)
I'm not a baby. (beat) I was baptized at thirteen. (beat) It's my choice too. (beat) No blood.

Arianna looks at the boy. Then at the clamped bags of O-negative, hanging there like an insult.

LOWERY
(beat, quietly)
Dr. Cummings. (beat) Call Franklin Bassett. (beat) Toussaint, Divine: take him to the OR and close that pelvis. (beat) Cell saver in the room. (beat) We buy time while the lawyers talk.

11 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MICU - FAMILY ROOM - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 9:14 AM

A small windowless room with a box of tissues and a painting of a lake. Cora Stroud sits on the sofa. Marc sits across from her. Natasha stands by the door. On the coffee table: the orange MOLST form.

NATASHA
(beat)
Ms. Stroud. (beat) I'm Dr. Donohue, the Chief of Surgery. (beat) There was supposed to be a DNR bracelet on your mother's wrist and a sign over her bed. (beat) There was supposed to be a nurse on that floor who knew her. (beat) There wasn't. (beat) That's not Dr. Bullock's failure. (beat) It's this hospital's. (beat) It's mine.

CORA
(beat)
He should have looked at the chart.

MARC
(beat, quietly)
Yes, ma'am. (beat) I should have. (beat) She had stopped breathing. (beat) I had about sixty seconds. (beat) The chart was at the nurses' station under twelve other charts, and the agency nurse didn't know where. (beat) I chose to treat. (beat) I'd make the same choice with the same sixty seconds. (beat) But I'm sorry it was the wrong choice for your mother.

Cora looks at him. She's a retired high school principal. She's heard a lot of apologies in her life. This one is different.

CORA
(beat)
What happens now?

NATASHA
(beat)
Your mother has the right to refuse the ventilator, the same as she had the right to refuse the tube. (beat) If that's her wish, and yours, we can take it out. (beat) With medicine to keep her comfortable. (beat) With you beside her.

CORA
(beat, barely)
She'll die.

MARC
(beat, gently)
Yes, ma'am. (beat) The way she wanted to. (beat) With somebody answering the phone.

12 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CVICU - BED 3 - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 9:38 AM

DR. CYRUS LANGLEY (78), a frail, distinguished man with a white mustache and a Howard University Medical Alumni pin on his robe, sits up after his valve replacement. Robert (49) reviews his chart. Amond is at the monitor.

LANGLEY
(beat, wry)
Bobby Bullock. (beat) You sewed in my valve. (beat) I taught you how to tie a knot in 1979, and look what you've done with it.

ROBERT
(warmly)
You taught me to tie a square knot with my left hand in the dark, Dr. Langley. (beat) You turned off the lights in the anatomy lab and made us practice until two in the morning.

LANGLEY
(to Amond)
He was terrible, young man. (beat) Absolutely terrible. (beat) Fast, though. (beat) And proud. (beat) And very pretty, which in those days on Georgia Avenue was a hazard.

AMOND
(dry)
He's still proud, sir.

LANGLEY
(beat, chuckling)
Of course he is. (beat) Bobby, I always said you married above yourself. (beat) The Donohue girl. (beat) You were lucky. (beat) There were others who'd have had you.

ROBERT
(beat, carefully)
Dr. Langley, you should rest.

LANGLEY
(beat, his eyes going distant, the anesthesia still in them)
That Ware girl. (beat) The Chicago resident. (beat) 1981. (beat) Brilliant. (beat) Brilliant and wild. (beat) She used to wait for you outside the call room, Bobby. (beat) I never knew what you said to her.

A silence. Robert's hand has stopped on the chart. Amond, at the monitor, keeps his eyes on the numbers, carefully, the way a person does who has just heard something he wasn't meant to.

ROBERT
(beat, evenly)
Nothing worth remembering, Dr. Langley. (beat) Get some sleep.

13 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CVICU - SUPPLY ROOM - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 9:47 AM

A narrow room lined with IV tubing and saline bags. Amond restocks a cart, because there's no one else to do it. Robert comes in and closes the door behind him.

ROBERT
(beat)
Dr. Baker.

AMOND
(not turning)
Sir.

ROBERT
(beat)
Dr. Langley is seventy-eight years old and just came off cardiopulmonary bypass. (beat) Patients say a great many things on postoperative day one.

AMOND
(beat, stacking saline bags)
Yes, sir.

ROBERT
(beat)
What did you hear?

Amond stops. He turns around and looks at his mentor. A long beat.

AMOND
(evenly)
Nothing worth remembering, sir. (beat) Your words.

Robert holds his gaze. Something passes between them: gratitude, and something like shame.

ROBERT
(beat, quietly)
Thank you, Amond.

AMOND
(beat)
Don't thank me, Dr. Bullock. (beat) I'm not keeping it for you. (beat) I'm keeping it because it's not mine. (beat) If Marc ever asks me a direct question, I won't lie to him.

ROBERT
(beat)
I'd never ask you to.

AMOND
(turning back to the cart)
Then we understand each other. (beat) Bed 3 needs a potassium rider at ten.

14 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - THE PIT - MORNING
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 10:02 AM

The ER, half staffed. Gloria hangs IV bags, draws blood, triages and runs the board all at once. Kennerly is right behind her, pushing a med cart he clearly doesn't understand.

GLORIA
(fast)
Bay 3, potassium chloride, forty milliequivalents, over four hours, not four minutes. (beat) You push potassium, Dr. Kennerly, you'll kill him faster than the hyperglycemia will.

KENNERLY
(beat)
I know that.

GLORIA
(beat)
You knew it in a lecture. (beat) Today you know it with your hands.

Kennerly sets the pump. Gloria checks it, nods and moves on. He follows her.

KENNERLY
(beat)
Nurse Pettiford. (beat) Why aren't you outside?

GLORIA
(beat, hanging a bag)
Because I'm management, Doctor. (beat) I signed a paper in 1998 that said if my nurses walk, I stay. (beat) And because if I walk, nobody in this ER knows where the Ativan is. (beat) My nurses are outside, and I'm in here, and we're both right. (beat) That's what a strike is. (beat) Two right things that can't stand in the same room.

KENNERLY
(beat)
Does it bother you?

GLORIA
(beat, stopping, looking at him)
I've been a nurse for thirty years. (beat) I've had eight patients on a night shift since 1984. (beat) I've watched three nurses quit and one die of a stroke in the break room at forty-six. (beat) What do you think?

15 EXT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - JACKSON AVENUE - PICKET LINE - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 10:31 AM

The picket line in the cold daylight. A few drivers honk in support. Kendra and Yvette march with their signs. Harmony, in her coat, comes out of the hospital carrying a cardboard tray of coffees. She stops at the barricade.

KENDRA
(beat, surprised)
Dr. Divine.

HARMONY
(handing the tray over)
Four hazelnut, four regular. (beat) From the Dunkin' on Vernon. (beat) I'm not crossing anything. (beat) I'm just bringing coffee.

A tall man in a TWU Local 100 jacket is walking the picket line with the nurses, holding a sign: "TRANSIT STANDS WITH NURSES." Harmony stares.

HARMONY
(beat)
Daddy?

HOWARD
(grinning, coughing into his glove)
Baby Girl. (beat) Day off. (beat) Thirty-one years, I've never walked past a picket line without walking it. (beat) Your mother's bringing chili at noon.

YVETTE
(laughing)
Your mother's bringing chili?

HARMONY
(beat, resigned)
My mother feeds every picket line in Queens.

Yvette sets down her bullhorn.

YVETTE
(beat, serious)
Dr. Divine. (beat) Bed 5 in the CVICU. (beat) Dash Duvall. (beat) He takes his amiodarone at two. (beat) The new girl won't know. (beat) He gets nauseous if you don't give him crackers first. (beat) Tell Dr. Ellison.

HARMONY
(beat)
You're on strike, and you're telling me about his crackers.

YVETTE
(beat, picking up the bullhorn again)
I'm on strike because I want to be able to tell somebody about his crackers.

16 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - GENERAL COUNSEL'S OFFICE - DAY

MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 10:54 AM

Bassett (47) is on the phone. Arianna stands across from his desk, in scrubs, pacing. On the speakerphone: a weary, patient judge.

JUDGE (V.O.)
(on the speakerphone)
...this is Justice Harold Dukes, Supreme Court, Queens County. (beat) Mr. Bassett, I have your emergency application. (beat) Sixteen-year-old male, hemorrhagic shock, hemoglobin five, parents refusing transfusion on religious grounds. (beat) The minor also refuses?

BASSETT
(beat)
He does, Your Honor.

JUDGE (V.O.)
(beat)
Dr. Cummings. Are you there?

ARIANNA
(beat)
Yes, Your Honor.

JUDGE (V.O.)
(beat)
In your medical opinion, Doctor, without transfusion, what is the likelihood that this young man dies today?

Arianna stops pacing.

ARIANNA
(beat, steady)
High, Your Honor. (beat) His hemoglobin is five-point-two and falling. (beat) His lactate is rising. (beat) His heart rate is one-thirty. (beat) The pelvis is closed, but he's still bleeding from the femur. (beat) Without blood in the next two to four hours, I believe he dies.

JUDGE (V.O.)
(beat)
And with it?

ARIANNA
(beat)
He goes to Bayside High School in June.

A long silence on the line.

JUDGE (V.O.)
(beat)
New York law recognizes the parents' sincerely held religious beliefs. (beat) It also recognizes the State's interest in the life of a child. (beat) When a minor's life is at imminent risk, the law favors life. (beat) The hospital is authorized to administer blood products as medically necessary to preserve the life of Josiah Wiggins. (beat) The order is limited to that. (beat) I'm faxing it now. (beat) God help all of you.

The fax machine in the corner begins to whir. Arianna stares at it.

17 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL ICU - BED 4 - DAY

MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 11:16 AM

Josiah, post-op, his pelvis held by a metal external fixator, his leg in traction, pale as paper. A cell saver machine sits in the corner, finished. Brother and Sister Wiggins at the bedside. Arianna comes in holding the faxed order and a unit of packed red cells.

Clifford sees the bag. He stands up.

CLIFFORD
(beat, very quietly)
No.

ARIANNA
(beat, steady)
Brother Wiggins. (beat) A judge of the Supreme Court of Queens County has ordered the hospital to transfuse Josiah to save his life. (beat) I'm sorry. (beat) I'm required to give him this.

JOYCE
(sobbing)
Please. (beat) Please don't.

Josiah opens his eyes. He sees the bag in Arianna's hand.

JOSIAH
(barely)
Dr. Cummings. (beat) Please. (beat) Please don't make me unclean.

Arianna stands at the bedside, the bag in her hand, the order in the other. Every person in the room is looking at her. She has never in her life been more sure of what was right, and never more sure that it was going to cost her.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

18 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL ICU - BED 4 - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 11:19 AM

Arianna hangs the bag. She spikes it. She connects the line to the IV in Josiah's arm. Her hands are steady. Her face is not. Clifford turns his back. Joyce falls to her knees by the bed and prays aloud.

JOYCE
(praying)
Jehovah, forgive them, for this is not his choice...

Arianna opens the clamp. Dark red blood begins to run down the tubing into the boy's arm. Josiah turns his face to the wall and cries silently.

ARIANNA
(very quietly, to Josiah)
It's my choice, Josiah. (beat) Not yours. (beat) You didn't choose this. (beat) Remember that. (beat) It's on me.

Josiah doesn't look at her. On the monitor: heart rate one twenty-eight. Then one twenty-two. Then one sixteen.

19 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - OR 4 - ORTHOPEDICS - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 11:48 AM

A second operation: Josiah's femur. Camille drives a long titanium rod down the center of the thighbone. Harmony holds the leg in traction. The circulator is an agency nurse who keeps handing Camille the wrong instruments.

CAMILLE
(patiently)
The reamer, sweetheart. (beat) The reamer is the long one with the spiral. (beat) That's a screwdriver.

AGENCY NURSE
(flustered)
I'm sorry, Doctor. (beat) At my last hospital they were in a different tray.

CAMILLE
(beat)
They're always in a different tray. (beat) Choir, tell her where the guide wire is.

HARMONY
(beat)
Third tray, blue wrap, behind the drill. (beat) Yvette showed me in September.

The nurse finds it. Camille seats the rod.

CAMILLE
(beat, low, to Harmony)
Is your papa really on the picket line?

HARMONY
(beat)
In his TWU jacket. (beat) My mother brought chili. (beat) Four pots.

CAMILLE
(beat, smiling behind her mask)
Mine sent me a text this morning. (beat) First one since Halsey Street. (beat) "Are you safe crossing the line?" (beat) That's all.

HARMONY
(beat)
What did you say?

CAMILLE
(beat)
I said, "Harmony walks me in, Papa." (beat) He didn't answer. (beat) But he didn't tell me not to.

20 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MICU - BED 2 - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 12:22 PM

Mrs. Stroud, intubated, awake. Cora sits beside her. Marc stands at the foot of the bed with a clipboard and a pen. On the clipboard, a simple alphabet board. Mrs. Stroud's frail hand holds the pen. Slowly, letter by letter, she points.

CORA
(reading aloud)
L. (beat) E. (beat) T. (beat) Let.

Mrs. Stroud keeps pointing.

CORA
(beat)
M. (beat) E. (beat) Me. (beat) G. (beat) O. (beat) Let me go.

Mrs. Stroud lets the pen drop. She looks at Marc. Then she reaches out and touches his wrist. Gently. She taps it twice, like a grandmother tapping a child's hand at church to say, "It's all right."

MARC
(beat, barely)
Mrs. Stroud. (beat) I'm so sorry.

She taps his wrist again. Then she points to the alphabet board one last time.

CORA
(beat, reading, crying)
Y. (beat) O. (beat) U. (beat) You.

MARC
(beat)
Me?

Mrs. Stroud nods weakly at the tube, then at Marc.

CORA
(beat, understanding)
She wants you to take it out. (beat) You put it in. (beat) She wants you to be the one.

21 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CHIEF'S OFFICE - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 12:47 PM

Natasha eats half a sandwich at her desk. Amond knocks on the open door. He looks uncomfortable.

NATASHA
(beat)
Dr. Baker. (beat) Sit.

AMOND
(staying on his feet)
Dr. Langley in CVICU Bed 3. (beat) His wife wants to see the Chief of Surgery. (beat) He says he danced with you at the Howard Medical Alumni ball in 1980. (beat) He wants to say hello.

NATASHA
(beat, surprised)
Cyrus Langley. (beat) He taught at Howard. (beat) He taught Robert.

AMOND
(beat)
Yes, ma'am.

Natasha studies Amond. He is not good at hiding things from people he respects.

NATASHA
(beat)
Is there something else, Dr. Baker?

AMOND
(beat, carefully)
He's still a little confused from the anesthesia, Dr. Donohue. (beat) He's saying things about 1981. (beat) I'd... (beat) I'd take what he says with a grain of salt.

Natasha sets down her sandwich.

NATASHA
(beat)
What kind of things?

AMOND
(beat)
Old things. (beat) That's all. (beat) I'm needed in step-down.

He leaves before she can ask again. Natasha sits very still, looking at the empty doorway.

22 INT. MONTY'S ON JACKSON - BAR - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 1:12 PM

The bar is packed with strikers warming up and doctors grabbing lunch. Monty (43) works double-time behind the bar. A sign taped to the register: "NURSES ON STRIKE DRINK HALF PRICE TODAY." Raven slumps on a stool, utterly exhausted. Marc sits beside her with a sandwich he isn't eating.

RAVEN
(beat, her head on the bar)
Eight beds. (beat) Two agency nurses. (beat) One of them called a balloon pump "the beepy thing." (beat) I've emptied fourteen Foleys. (beat) I've turned Mr. Langley six times. (beat) I hung Dash's amiodarone and I almost forgot his crackers.

MARC
(beat)
Harmony told you about the crackers?

RAVEN
(beat)
Yvette told Harmony. (beat) From the picket line. (beat) Marc, they know everything. (beat) Every cracker. Every blanket. Every patient's favorite pillow. (beat) And we treat them like furniture.

MONTY
(setting down two coffees)
I've been watching nurses come in here since 1998. (beat) The surgeons come in here and tell me about their cases. (beat) The nurses come in here and tell me about their patients. (beat) There's a difference.

Marc looks at his untouched sandwich.

MARC
(beat, quietly)
I'm taking a tube out at three. (beat) One I put in. (beat) Because a nurse wasn't there to tell me not to.

23 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL FLOOR - NURSES' STATION - DAY

MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 1:41 PM

Elxa behind the desk on her purple cushion, three phones going, running the whole surgical service from a chair. Clayton comes by, takes one look at her and leans over the counter.

CLAYTON
(beat)
You're having contractions.

ELXA
(into a phone)
Six North needs a second agency nurse. Now. (beat, hanging up, to Clayton) I'm not.

CLAYTON
(beat)
Elxa. (beat) I'm a fetal surgeon. (beat) I can see your belly tighten through your scrubs. (beat) Every twelve minutes since I walked up.

ELXA
(beat)
Practice contractions. (beat) Thirty-eight and five. (beat) It's normal.

CLAYTON
(beat)
It is normal. (beat) It's also how labor starts. (beat) When did you last see Dr. Hampton?

ELXA
(beat, grudging)
Friday. (beat) Two centimeters. (beat) She says it could be tomorrow. (beat) Or two weeks.

CLAYTON
(beat)
Then sit very still in that chair, Dr. Bullock. (beat) And if they come every five minutes, you call her. (beat) Not me. (beat) Not your mother. (beat) Her.

Elxa picks up another ringing phone. She doesn't argue.

24 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL ICU - BED 4 - DAY

MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 2:12 PM

Josiah, pinker now, two units in, his heart rate down to ninety-eight. The empty blood bags have been taken away. Joyce sits in the chair, her Bible closed in her lap, staring at nothing. Clifford stands at the window. Arianna checks the fixator pins.

CLIFFORD
(beat, not turning)
Dr. Cummings. (beat) You saved my son's body.

ARIANNA
(beat)
Yes, sir.

CLIFFORD
(beat, turning to face her)
And in the eyes of our faith, you've taken something from him he can never get back. (beat) Do you understand that?

ARIANNA
(beat)
No, sir. (beat) I don't understand it. (beat) But I believe that you believe it. (beat) And I know it's real for you. (beat) And I did it anyway.

CLIFFORD
(beat)
Why?

ARIANNA
(beat, quietly)
Because my father wasn't there to choose for me when I was sixteen, Brother Wiggins. (beat) He was on a corner in East Liberty. (beat) And I've spent ten years wishing somebody had loved me enough to fight about anything. (beat) You love your son enough to let him die for what you believe. (beat) I can't argue with that. (beat) I just couldn't stand there and watch it.

Clifford looks at her for a very long time.

CLIFFORD
(beat)
He will be disfellowshipped, perhaps. (beat) Or perhaps not, since it was forced. (beat) The elders will decide. (beat) Either way, he is my son. (beat) I will take him home.

ARIANNA
(beat)
I'll carry it, Brother Wiggins. (beat) Whatever it costs him with your church. (beat) I'll carry it.

25 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MICU - BED 2 - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 3:00 PM

The curtains are drawn. Soft light. A morphine drip runs. Cora holds her mother's hand on one side of the bed. A hospital chaplain stands quietly in the corner. Marc stands at the head of the bed in gloves. The respiratory therapist, an agency tech, stands ready by the ventilator.

MARC
(gently)
Mrs. Stroud. (beat) Are you ready?

Mrs. Stroud looks up at him. She nods. Once.

MARC
(to the respiratory therapist, quietly)
Deflate the cuff.

The therapist deflates the balloon. Marc loosens the tape. He looks at Cora. Cora nods. Marc slides the tube out, gently, in one smooth motion, the reverse of what he did at 7:16 that morning.

END OF ACT THREE

ACT FOUR

26 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MICU - BED 2 - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 3:27 PM

Mrs. Stroud breathes on her own, slowly, through a soft oxygen cannula. Her eyes are closed. Cora sits on the edge of the bed, holding her mother's hand, singing very softly. "Precious Lord, take my hand." Marc stands in the corner by the window. The chaplain has gone.

Mrs. Stroud opens her eyes one last time. She looks at her daughter. Then she turns her head slightly and looks at Marc in the corner. She lifts one finger off the blanket. A small wave.

Marc lifts his hand back.

Her breathing slows. Long pauses. Then a last soft breath, and stillness. The monitor has been turned off. Nobody needs it.

CORA
(whispering)
She answered the phone.

Marc steps forward and listens with his stethoscope for a full minute.

MARC
(gently)
Time of death, three twenty-seven p.m.

Cora lays her head on her mother's chest.

27 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MICU - CORRIDOR - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 3:44 PM

Cora Stroud comes out of the room in her church coat with her mother's pocketbook over her arm. Marc waits by the window. She stops in front of him and opens the pocketbook. She takes out a worn paper bookmark, a church fan from Mount Olivet Baptist with a faded picture of Jesus on one side and the words to "Precious Lord" on the other.

CORA
(beat)
She kept this in her hymnal for sixty years. (beat) It was in her pocketbook this morning. (beat) She'd have wanted the young man who answered the phone to have it.

MARC
(barely)
Ms. Stroud, I didn't answer the phone. (beat) I picked it up when she'd already hung up.

CORA
(beat, pressing it into his hand)
You put it right back down when she asked you to, Dr. Bullock. (beat) That's the part she'd remember. (beat) That's the part I'll remember.

She walks to the elevator. Marc stands in the corridor holding the paper fan.

28 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - STAIRWELL B - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 3:51 PM

Marc sits on the stairs with his elbows on his knees. Esther comes down from the Neuro ICU above, sees him and sits down beside him, close, without asking.

ESTHER
(beat)
Mrs. Stroud.

MARC
(beat)
I put it in at seven-sixteen. (beat) I took it out at three. (beat) She died at three twenty-seven. (beat) For eight hours, I kept her from doing the one thing she'd asked everybody to let her do.

ESTHER
(beat)
You didn't know.

MARC
(beat)
Somebody did. (beat) Her nurse knew. (beat) Her regular nurse. (beat) Her name was Marisol. (beat) Cora told me. (beat) Marisol put the bracelet on every morning. (beat) Marisol's on Jackson Avenue holding a sign that says "One nurse, eight patients."

Esther takes his hand. This time she doesn't let go after a minute.

ESTHER
(beat, quietly)
She waved at you, Marc. (beat) The nurse in the MICU told me. (beat) At the end. (beat) She waved.

MARC
(beat, barely)
She waved.

29 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CVICU - BED 3 - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 4:16 PM

Dr. Langley sits up, clearer now. His wife, MRS. EUNICE LANGLEY (76), sits beside him. Natasha comes in, still in scrubs, and smiles warmly.

NATASHA
(beat)
Dr. Langley. (beat) Mrs. Langley. (beat) Natasha Donohue.

LANGLEY
(delighted)
The Donohue girl. (beat) Look at you. (beat) Chief of Surgery. (beat) I danced with you in 1980 at the alumni ball at the Shoreham. (beat) You were expecting and wearing green.

NATASHA
(beat, laughing)
I was pregnant with Grace, Dr. Langley. (beat) Marc was a year old, and Elxa was three. (beat) I was wearing green, and I was exhausted.

EUNICE
(patting her husband's hand)
He mixes up the years now.

LANGLEY
(beat)
Bobby married above himself. (beat) I told him so. (beat) I told all of them. (beat) There were girls who chased that boy all over Georgia Avenue. (beat) The Ware girl. (beat) Chicago. (beat) Delphine. (beat) Brilliant. (beat) Wild as a summer storm. (beat) She went back to Chicago in '82, and he married you and never looked back.

A beat. Natasha's smile doesn't move. But something behind it goes absolutely still.

NATASHA
(beat, lightly)
Robert married me in 1978, Dr. Langley.

LANGLEY
(beat, confused)
Did he? (beat) Well. (beat) Then he never looked back after that, either.

EUNICE
(gently)
Cyrus. You're tired.

NATASHA
(beat, smoothing his blanket)
Get some rest, Dr. Langley. (beat) It was lovely to see you.

She walks out. In the hallway, she stops beside the window and puts a hand flat on the glass. "Chicago." "Delphine." The cream envelope in Robert's coat pocket. The postmark.

30 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CVICU - BED 5 - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 4:42 PM

Dash sits on the edge of the bed with a towel around his shoulders, leaning forward over a basin on the tray table. Raven, in gloves, washes his hair with a cup of warm water and no-rinse shampoo. Glenda has gone to the cafeteria. The Panthers blanket Yvette brought from home lies across the bed.

DASH
(eyes closed)
Day eighty. (beat) First time anybody's washed my hair since Thanksgiving.

RAVEN
(working gently around the PICC line)
The nurses usually do it on Mondays. (beat) Yvette told Harmony to tell me. (beat) Mondays, crackers before amiodarone, the Panthers blanket on the left side because you sleep on your right.

DASH
(beat)
She told you all that from the picket line?

RAVEN
(beat)
She told me all that from the picket line.

She pours warm water over his head. He sighs.

DASH
(beat, quietly)
Raven. (beat) You've been my nurse all day. (beat) You hung my drips. You turned me. You checked my pads. (beat) You washed my hair. (beat) That's the closest anybody's been to me in eighty days.

RAVEN
(beat, her hands still in his hair)
I know.

DASH
(beat)
I can't take it back tomorrow when the nurses come back. (beat) I can't go back to you being Dr. Ellison at the foot of the bed.

Raven pours the last cup of water and wraps the towel around his head. Then she does something she's never done. She leans down and rests her forehead against the top of his towel-wrapped head, just for a moment.

RAVEN
(barely)
Neither can I.

31 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - NURSE MANAGER'S OFFICE - DAY
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 5:36 PM

A cramped office with a desk buried in schedules. Gloria sits behind it, eating crackers. Rountree stands in the doorway in her red suit, holding a memo.

ROUNTREE
(beat)
Nurse Pettiford. (beat) I'm told you intend to spend your dinner break on the picket line.

GLORIA
(beat, not looking up)
You're told correctly, Dr. Rountree.

ROUNTREE
(beat)
You're management. (beat) It would be inappropriate.

GLORIA
(beat, setting down the crackers)
Dr. Rountree. (beat) I have been a nurse in this building since 1975. (beat) I started as an aide, emptying bedpans for a dollar ninety an hour. (beat) I've had four CEOs. (beat) You're the first one who's never once walked the floors at three in the morning. (beat) My contract gives me thirty minutes for dinner, and it doesn't tell me where to eat it.

ROUNTREE
(beat, coolly)
And if I put a letter in your file?

GLORIA
(beat, standing, putting on her coat)
Then put it next to the thirty years of evaluations that say "exceeds expectations." (beat) And the plaque from 1993, when I ran this ER for nineteen hours straight after the World Trade Center bombing. (beat) And the one from September 2001. (beat) My file's thick, Dr. Rountree. (beat) It can take a letter.

She walks past Rountree into the corridor. Rountree stands alone in the doorway, looking at the schedules on the desk: eight patients to a nurse, every night, in Gloria's handwriting.

32 EXT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - JACKSON AVENUE - PICKET LINE - DUSK
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 5:58 PM

Dusk. The picket line, thinner in the cold, sustained by four steaming pots of chili on a folding table under a pop-up tent. Lillian Divine ladles it out. Howard walks the line with the nurses. The revolving door turns. Gloria comes out, coat over her scrubs, on her dinner break. Kennerly comes out behind her.

Gloria walks straight to the barricade. The nurses stop marching. Gloria picks up a sign leaning against the barricade, one that reads "WE CARE FOR YOU -- WHO CARES FOR US?" She holds it up beside Yvette for exactly thirty seconds, while every nurse on the line watches her. Then she sets it down.

GLORIA
(beat)
That's my dinner break. (beat) Thirty minutes. (beat) The contract says I can spend it any way I want.

The nurses cheer. Yvette hugs her. Lillian presses a bowl of chili into Gloria's hands. Kennerly stands awkwardly at the edge of the tent. Lillian sees him.

LILLIAN
(beat, beaming)
That's the boy from the bench. (beat) Come here, baby. (beat) You look hungry.

KENNERLY
(beat, barely)
Mrs. Divine.

LILLIAN
(handing him a bowl)
Eat. (beat) And give your mother a call this week.

KENNERLY
(beat)
My father's in Scottsdale, ma'am. (beat) With his third wife. (beat) My mother's in Phoenix. (beat) They don't talk.

LILLIAN
(beat, patting his cheek)
Then call both of them, baby. (beat) It's a long way to be from your people.

33 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - INTERNS' LOCKER ROOM - NIGHT

MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 6:23 PM

Raven sits on the bench, too tired to change. Her scrubs are stained. Her hair has come loose. The door opens. Arianna comes in from the ER, equally wrecked, and stops when she sees her. They haven't spoken properly in ten days.

ARIANNA
(beat)
You look terrible.

RAVEN
(beat)
Fourteen Foleys. (beat) You?

ARIANNA
(beat, sitting at the other end of the bench)
A court order. (beat) I transfused a sixteen-year-old Jehovah's Witness while his mother prayed for my soul on the floor. (beat) He asked me not to make him unclean.

Raven looks at her. Arianna stares at her own hands.

RAVEN
(beat, quietly)
Are you okay?

ARIANNA
(beat)
No.

Raven gets up, opens her own locker, takes out a granola bar and a carton of chocolate milk and sets them on the bench beside Arianna. Then she sits back down at the other end.

ARIANNA
(beat, not looking at her)
You still keep chocolate milk in your locker.

RAVEN
(beat)
For you. (beat) Since October. (beat) I never stopped.

Arianna picks up the milk. She opens it. She drinks it. Neither of them moves closer. Neither of them leaves.

34 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - PARKING GARAGE - LEVEL 2 - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 7:02 PM

The concrete garage, empty and echoing. Natasha, in her coat, walks to Robert's silver Mercedes. She takes a spare key from her purse. She unlocks the passenger door and sits down. She opens the glove compartment.

On top of the owner's manual: a small, yellowed envelope in an elegant woman's hand. "Robert Bullock -- Personal." Sealed.

Natasha takes it out. She holds it in both hands. The garage is silent except for the hum of a fluorescent light. She turns it over. The seal is unbroken. She runs her thumb along the edge of the flap.

END OF ACT FOUR

ACT FIVE

35 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - PARKING GARAGE - LEVEL 2 - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 7:04 PM

Natasha sits in the passenger seat with the envelope. Her thumb rests on the flap. She could open it. It would take one second. She closes her eyes.

NATASHA
(barely, to herself)
Secrets keep you sick.

She opens her eyes. She puts the envelope back in the glove compartment, exactly as she found it, on top of the owner's manual. She closes the compartment. She gets out of the car, locks it and stands beside it in the empty garage, her keys in her hand.

NATASHA
(beat, quietly)
But they're his to tell.

36 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL ICU - BED 4 - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 7:31 PM

Josiah, stable now, sits propped up with his external fixator. His parents have gone to the cafeteria. Arianna checks the pin sites. Josiah watches her.

JOSIAH
(beat)
Are you going to get in trouble?

ARIANNA
(beat, surprised)
What?

JOSIAH
(beat)
With the hospital. (beat) For the blood. (beat) My dad was yelling at the lawyer in the hallway.

ARIANNA
(beat)
No. (beat) The judge ordered it. (beat) I'm fine.

JOSIAH
(beat)
Are you going to get in trouble with God?

Arianna stops working on the pin site.

ARIANNA
(beat, honestly)
I don't know, Josiah. (beat) I don't know much about God. (beat) I know about bleeding.

JOSIAH
(beat, quietly)
I'm still mad at you.

ARIANNA
(beat)
I know.

JOSIAH
(beat)
But I'm glad I'm going to see my sister's graduation in June. (beat) Is that a sin?

ARIANNA
(beat, softly)
I don't think so. (beat) I think that's just being sixteen.

37 INT. CLAYTON'S SUBLET - BROOKLYN HEIGHTS - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 8:02 PM

Clayton at his laptop on the coffee table. Esther comes in and drops her bag. He turns the laptop toward her. An email.

"FROM: msloan@partners.org. TO: chartwell@qgh.org. SUBJECT: The 13th. Clay -- Starting the 13th. Rountree's put me in the corner office on Seven. If it's easier for her, I'll take the stairs on the east side and never use the west elevators. Tell her that. Tell her whatever she needs. -M."

Esther reads it twice. She sits down on the arm of the sofa.

ESTHER
(beat)
He's going to take the stairs.

CLAYTON
(beat)
He's offering to.

ESTHER
(beat)
For a year? (beat) For five?

CLAYTON
(beat)
He would. (beat) You know he would.

Esther closes the laptop.

ESTHER
(beat)
I don't want him to take the stairs, Clayton. (beat) I don't want to work in a building where a man I loved like a brother hides in a stairwell so I don't have to see him. (beat) That's not forgiveness. (beat) It's a fire drill.

CLAYTON
(beat)
Then what do you want?

ESTHER
(beat, standing)
I want him to use the elevator. (beat) And I want to be able to stand in it with him. (beat) I'm just not there yet.

38 INT. NATASHA AND ROBERT'S BROWNSTONE - RIVERSIDE DRIVE - KITCHEN - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 8:39 PM

Robert at the stove, making his mother's red beans and rice, in a cardigan. Natasha comes in, takes off her coat, and sits at the kitchen island. She watches him cook for a long moment.

NATASHA
(beat)
I saw Cyrus Langley today.

ROBERT
(stirring)
He's doing well. (beat) The valve's perfect.

NATASHA
(beat)
He thought I was wearing green in 1980.

ROBERT
(beat, smiling)
You were.

NATASHA
(beat)
He mentioned a resident. (beat) From Chicago. (beat) Delphine Ware.

Robert's spoon stops for half a second. Then it keeps stirring.

ROBERT
(beat, evenly)
She was a surgery resident at Howard. (beat) Brilliant. (beat) She went back to Chicago. (beat) I heard she died a few years ago. (beat) A stroke.

NATASHA
(beat)
That's all?

ROBERT
(beat, not turning around)
That's what I know, Tasha.

Natasha looks at her husband's back. Twenty-seven years of marriage. Fifteen years of sobriety. She knows exactly what a man sounds like when he's choosing his words.

NATASHA
(beat, quietly)
One day, I'm going to ask you that again. (beat) And you're going to tell me the rest of it. (beat) Not tonight. (beat) But one day.

ROBERT
(beat, finally turning, the spoon in his hand)
Tasha...

NATASHA
(beat, standing)
The beans are burning, Robert.

39 INT. ELXA AND RUSSELL'S HOUSE - ST. ALBANS - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 9:12 PM

Elxa sits on the purple birthing ball, rocking, breathing through her nose. Russell sits on the floor with a stopwatch and a notepad covered in times. The TV plays

ESPN: Super Bowl XL hype. "STEELERS VS. SEAHAWKS -- SUNDAY -- DETROIT."

RUSSELL
(checking the stopwatch)
Nine minutes. (beat) Then eleven. (beat) Then eight. (beat) Then twelve. (beat) Irregular.

ELXA
(beat, breathing out)
Prodromal. (beat) Dr. Hampton said it could go like this for days.

RUSSELL
(beat)
Days.

ELXA
(beat)
Days, Russell. (beat) He's in no hurry. (beat) He's a Bullock. (beat) He'll come when he's good and ready, and he'll make an entrance.

RUSSELL
(beat, looking at the TV)
Please don't let him come during the Super Bowl.

ELXA
(beat, deadpan)
I'll ask him.

40 INT. MONTY'S ON JACKSON - BAR - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 9:44 PM

The bar is full of nurses on their way off the line for the night. Kendra Wallace sits at the bar in her red NYSNA jacket. Kennerly takes the stool next to her. Monty slides them each a half-price beer.

KENDRA
(beat)
You crossed the line.

KENNERLY
(beat)
I'm a doctor. (beat) I don't have a line. (beat) I had a med cart I didn't understand and Gloria Pettiford yelling at me about potassium for twelve hours.

KENDRA
(beat, almost smiling)
How'd you do?

KENNERLY
(beat)
I emptied eleven Foleys. (beat) I'm never going to look at a Foley the same way again.

KENDRA
(beat)
Welcome to my life.

KENNERLY
(beat)
I'm sorry. (beat) About September. (beat) The cafeteria. (beat) I used you to spread it.

Kendra looks at him, surprised.

KENDRA
(beat)
Bryce Kennerly. (beat) Are you apologizing?

KENNERLY
(beat)
It's a correction. (beat) There's a difference.

MONTY
(wiping a glass, to no one)
He says that a lot lately.

41 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - KITCHEN - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 10:21 PM

The kitchen. Marc and Amond eat cold Chinese food out of the cartons. Mercy sits at Amond's feet, begging for a dumpling, and gets one.

AMOND
(beat)
Marc. (beat) If I knew something about your father, would you want me to tell you?

Marc puts down his chopsticks.

MARC
(beat)
Is it about a patient?

AMOND
(beat)
No.

MARC
(beat)
Is it going to hurt someone if you don't?

AMOND
(beat, thinking hard)
No. (beat) Not today.

Marc looks at his best friend for a long moment.

MARC
(beat)
Then it's his to tell, Amond. (beat) Not yours. (beat) You told me that.

AMOND
(beat)
I did.

MARC
(beat, picking up his chopsticks again)
You were right.

Amond nods. He feeds Mercy another dumpling. Neither of them says anything else.

TAG

42 EXT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - JACKSON AVENUE - PICKET LINE - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 11:47 PM

The overnight picket: a dozen nurses in red jackets around a barrel fire, holding candles in paper cups. Yvette Banks reads names from a list in a low voice: nurses who died on the job, nurses who quit, the nurse who had a stroke in the break room at forty-six. Kendra holds a candle.

MARC (V.O.)
Every hospital runs on one secret.

43 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CVICU - BED 5 - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 11:52 PM

Dash asleep on his right side, his hair clean, the Panthers blanket tucked on his left side exactly the way Yvette said. Raven's gone home. An agency nurse checks his pump, glances at the blanket, and leaves it exactly where it is.

MARC (V.O.)
It's not the surgeons who keep people alive. (beat) Not really.

44 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MICU - BED 2 - NIGHT
MONDAY, JANUARY 30, 2006 - 11:58 PM

The bed has been stripped and remade, empty. On the windowsill, someone has left a single paper cup with a candle in it, burning down. Beside it: a hospital bracelet, orange, the letters "DNR" printed on it. A nurse found it in the morning's laundry. It was in the wrong drawer.

MARC (V.O.)
It's the people who know where the bracelet goes. (beat) Which side the blanket goes on. (beat) Who needs crackers before the two o'clock.

The candle flickers.

MARC (V.O.)
And you never know how much they hold up until the day they set it down.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE

Media Companion: Episode 2x15

Off-screen media around the episode, in chronological order. Not counted in page length (MA-009 §5).

NEW YORK DAILY NEWS: "NURSES WALK AT QUEENS GRACE"

Monday, January 30, 2006

"Some 260 registered nurses at Queens Grace Hospital in Long Island City walked off the job at 7 a.m. today for a 24-hour strike over staffing ratios and mandatory overtime, after giving the 10-day notice federal law requires of health care unions. Hospital officials said 94 replacement nurses from an agency would keep 'all essential services' open." (A fictional strike at a fictional hospital.)

ASSOCIATED PRESS: "SENATE CLEARS WAY FOR ALITO VOTE" / "ABC ANCHOR WOODRUFF HURT IN IRAQ"

Monday, January 30, 2006

"WASHINGTON (AP) -- The Senate voted 72-25 to end debate on Samuel Alito's Supreme Court nomination, setting up a confirmation vote Tuesday..." / "ABC News co-anchor Bob Woodruff and a cameraman were seriously injured Sunday by a roadside bomb near Taji, Iraq..."

QueensGraceConfidential (Blogger)

Monday, January 30, 2006, 7:12 PM

"DAY OF THE WALKOUT. We saw doctors emptying Foleys. We saw Nurse P. hold a picket sign for exactly thirty seconds on her dinner break ('the contract says I can'). We saw an intern's mother feed the line FOUR POTS OF CHILI and an MTA bus driver march with the nurses in his TWU jacket. We also heard a 91-year-old patient waved goodbye to the intern who took out her breathing tube. If you don't think nurses matter, come spend a day on Six North. Solidarity." Comments (3,118).

Order of the Supreme Court of the State of New York, County of Queens (excerpt)

Monday, January 30, 2006, 11:04 AM (by fax)

"IN THE MATTER OF THE APPLICATION OF QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL re: J.W., an infant... ORDERED, that the hospital is authorized to administer blood and blood products as medically necessary to preserve the life of the infant, and for no other purpose. -- Hon. Harold Dukes, J.S.C."

Email: Malcolm Sloan to Clayton Hartwell

Monday, January 30, 2006, 4:48 PM

"Clay -- Starting the 13th. Rountree's put me in the corner office on Seven. If it's easier for her, I'll take the stairs on the east side and never use the west elevators. Tell her that. Tell her whatever she needs. -M."

MOLST form (Lavinia Stroud), Section A

Signed 2003

"DO NOT RESUSCITATE (DNR). DO NOT INTUBATE (DNI)." (The orange DNR bracelet was found in the wrong laundry drawer on January 30.)

Continuity Sheet: Episode 2x15

New Canon Established

- **THE QGH NURSES' STRIKE** (fictional, NYSNA): about 260 RNs on a 24-hour strike from 7 AM January 30 to 7 AM January 31 over staffing ratios (Six North ran 1:8 on nights) and mandatory overtime. Ten-day notice was given January 20. Rountree brought in 94 agency nurses, and the residents and interns nursed. **Gloria (management) stayed in**, left hazelnut coffee on the barricade, and held a picket sign for 30 seconds on her dinner break ('the contract says I can'). Yvette Banks led the line with a bullhorn. Howard marched in his TWU jacket, and Lillian brought four pots of chili. Rountree threatened discipline for refusing overtime. Natasha argued that the strike is 'just when we finally noticed.'
- **MARC AND THE DNR** (Grey's 2x15 beat): at 7:16 AM Marc found Mrs. Lavinia Stroud (91) in respiratory arrest on Six North with no bracelet, no sign and no nurse (her regular nurse, Marisol, was on strike), and intubated her. Her MOLST (DNR/DNI, 2003) was on page one of the chart, buried at the station. Natasha told the daughter it was 'this hospital's' failure. Mrs. Stroud spelled 'LET ME GO' and then 'YOU.' **Marc did the terminal extubation at 3:00 PM.** She waved at him and died at 3:27 PM; Marc called it. The bracelet turned up in the wrong laundry drawer.
- **ARIANNA AND THE JEHOVAH'S WITNESS MINOR** (Grey's 2x15 beat): Josiah Wiggins (16, baptized at 13) was in a car crash on the Clearview (his mother was driving on black ice), with an open-book pelvis and femur fracture and a hemoglobin of 5.2. He and his parents refused blood. They accepted a cell saver and EPO. Bassett got an emergency order from **Justice Harold Dukes**, and **Arianna transfused** while Joyce prayed on the floor. 'It's my choice. Not yours. It's on me.' Arianna to Clifford: 'I've spent ten years wishing somebody had loved me enough to fight about anything.' Camille and Harmony did an ex-fix and an IM femoral nail. Josiah: 'I'm still mad at you... But I'm glad I'm going to see my sister's graduation.'
- **THE DELPHINE WARE ALLUSION** (counterpart of the Webber and Ellis allusion): **Dr. Cyrus Langley** (78), Robert's Howard professor in 1979 (he taught left-handed knots in the dark), had a valve replacement by Robert. Still confused from anesthesia, he told Robert and Amond, and then Natasha: 'That Ware girl. Chicago. Delphine... 1981... She used to wait for you outside the call room, Bobby.' **Natasha connected it to the Chicago postmark. Natasha found the sealed letter in Robert's glove compartment and did NOT open it** ('they're his to tell'). That night Robert gave the partial truth: 'She was a surgery resident at Howard... She died... a stroke.' Natasha: 'One day, I'm going to ask you that again.' **Amond overheard Langley** and chose not to tell Marc. Marc: 'Then it's his to tell.' The letter remains unopened.
- **Raven and Dash:** Raven nursed him all day (the amiodarone at 2 PM with crackers first, the Panthers blanket on his left side, hair washed on Mondays, all relayed by Yvette through Harmony from the picket line). She washed his hair and rested her forehead on his towel-wrapped head. Dash: 'I can't go back to you being Dr. Ellison.' Raven: 'Neither can I.' **Raven and Arianna:** a small truce in the locker room. Raven still keeps chocolate milk for her, 'since October.'
- **Malcolm emailed Clayton:** he starts on February 13 in the corner office on Seven and offered to use only the east stairs. Esther: 'That's not forgiveness. It's a fire drill... I want him to use the

elevator... I'm just not there yet.' **Elxa (38w5d)** is on desk duty from January 30 (cushion and three phones), 2 cm dilated at Friday's visit with Dr. Hampton, and having prodromal contractions every 8 to 12 minutes. Russell: 'Please don't let him come during the Super Bowl.'

- **Kennerly apologized to Kendra** for using her to spread the rumor in September ('It's a correction'). His father is in Scottsdale with his third wife, and his mother is in Phoenix; they don't talk. Lillian told him to call both. Gloria: 'Two right things that can't stand in the same room.' She has worked eight-patient nights since 1984 and saw a nurse die of a stroke in the break room at 46.

Knowledge Tracker (as of January 30, 2006)

Item	Who knows
Delphine Ware's name and Chicago	Natasha (suspects an old relationship), Amond (overheard Langley), Robert
The sealed letter's existence	Robert; Natasha (saw it, didn't open it; Robert doesn't know she saw it)
Mariah Pettaway	No one. Locked until Season 11
Raven and Dash	Deepening; Glenda, Arianna, Harmony, Marc and Yvette all aware
Malcolm's start date (February 13)	Esther, Clayton, Natasha, Rountree; the blog soon

Patient Registry

Patient	DOB / age	Diagnosis	Procedure / surgeon	Outcome
Mrs. Lavinia Stroud	10/8/1914 (91)	Respiratory arrest; DNR/DNI not visible	Intubation 7:16 AM; terminal extubation 3:00 PM (Bullock)	Died at 3:27 PM, comfort care
Josiah Wiggins	9/9/1989 (16)	Open-book pelvis, right femur fracture, hemorrhagic shock (Hgb 5.2)	Pelvic binder, ex-fix, IM nail (Toussaint; Divine); court-ordered transfusion, 2 units (Cummings)	Stable; HR 98
Dr. Cyrus Langley	7/17/1927 (78)	Valve replacement, post-op	(R. Bullock; Baker; Ellison as nurse)	Recovering; confused from anesthesia
Darius 'Dash' Duvall	8/8/1971 (34)	Status 1A, day 80; amiodarone	Nursed by Ellison	Stable

New Characters

- **Dr. Cyrus Langley** (b. July 17, 1927), professor of surgery at Howard (taught Robert in 1979), and **Mrs. Eunice Langley** (b. May 5, 1929). **Mrs. Lavinia Stroud** (b. October 8, 1914) and **Cora Stroud** (b. April 30, 1939), a retired principal.
- **Josiah Wiggins** (b. September 9, 1989; Bayside High School), with **Brother Clifford** (b. June 12, 1961) and **Sister Joyce Wiggins** (b. November 1, 1963). **Justice Harold Dukes** (b. February 2, 1949; voice only). Kendra Wallace and Yvette Banks lead the picket.

Real-World Accuracy Notes

- The NLRA's Section 8(g) requires unions at health care institutions to give 10 days' notice before a strike, and one-day strikes with agency replacement nurses are common in New York (NYSNA). On January 30, 2006, the Senate invoked cloture on Samuel Alito's nomination 72-25 (he was confirmed January 31), and on January 29 ABC's Bob Woodruff was badly injured in Iraq. Super Bowl XL (Steelers vs. Seahawks) was played in Detroit on February 5, 2006. The Shoreham is a Washington hotel. Howard University Hospital replaced Freedmen's in 1975.
- Medicine: a MOLST/DNR order must be honored, and a misplaced bracelet or chart is a system failure. A patient with capacity may refuse continued ventilation, and terminal extubation with comfort medication is ethically equivalent to withholding. Jehovah's Witnesses refuse whole blood and major components, but many accept a cell saver in continuous circuit, EPO and iron. For minors facing imminent death, New York courts routinely authorize transfusion over parental and minor objection. Open-book pelvic fractures are stabilized with a binder, then external fixation. Prodromal labor can produce irregular contractions for days.